

study. Look at it from a listener's point of view: When you know where an argument is leading, you can judge how well the points substantiate the conclusion as the argument unfolds.

In a sense, the facts that make up the argument are just packaging; they usually won't be remembered.

Another thing to consider is that in many informal presentation situations (in the hall, in the elevator) you may be cut off at any moment. Even in formal meetings you never know what key figure may have to leave early. So, whatever the circumstance, give them your message early.

Where to start. Begin. Grab a pad and a pencil; you're ready to start creating your presentation. First state your conclusion, your recommendation, and your action plan. Most often this should take the form of a direct call for action.

- "Lease a car from us. It will give you convenience, flexibility, and reliability."
- "I recommend that we reorganize our materials supply system and keep this plant open."
- "My committee's recommendation is that the management invest four-point-seven million dollars in this new line of business. We'd like your approval."

What's *your* conclusion? Write it down. Say it out loud. How does it sound to you? Make it clear and strong. You're off and running. Once your conclusion is set, the rest of your presentation should fall into place.

Step Two. List the selling points that support your conclusion.

These two elements—your *conclusion* and *action plan* and your list of *selling points*—form the backbone of your presentation. Here's how it works:

Conceptually, we divide presentations into three sections: